Disturbed

By Brad Bosen

The nursery of a city hospital. The audience is where the babies would be. The actors are on the other side of the "glass" Daphne is peering out at the audience happily cooing and making faces at the "babies. Bob enters. About the same age as Daphne, he is obviously in a very dark mood. He stares blankly at the babies, seemingly oblivious to Daphne's continued antics. Daphne, sensing Bob's depression, begins to include him -- pointing him out to the babies, making grouchy faces, trying to improve his mood until a long, mournful sigh from Bob stops her.

INTRODUCTION

Emotional scars, although they may heal over time or are invisible to the world at large, never really disappear. But we develop coping mechanisms to deal with the pain and to protect ourselves. We build walls – much like this imaginary wall dividing Daphne and Bob from the babies on the other side. An invisible glass wall built for safety.

But these coping mechanisms – these walls – are they healthy or are they merely survival techniques to cover up the fact that we are all, in our own way . . .

Disturbed by Brad Boesen

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DAPHNE: *[a bit hesitant]* Are you alright? *[Silence. Bob continues to stare ahead]* Sir? *[growing more concerned. Agonizing over whether to help or leave him alone, she softly touches his elbow. He looks at her and she quickly pulls her hand back]* I'm sorry. . . Are you alright? You look. . .

BOB: Yeah. *[he looks at the babies, senses she's not convinced, turns back]* I'm fine. *[flashes an unconvincing smile and turns back towards the babies]*

DAPHNE: *[playing along]* Oh. . . ok. . . well, good. *[uncomfortable with the silence, but not wanting to leave, she decides to fill it]* I love babies. I come here almost every day to look at them. I work right across the street. At that little diner. By the time lunch break rolls around I'm so tired of all that food I just don't even want to think about eating, so I come over here and look at them. *[one of the babies does something cute]* Ahhhhhh! Look at him! *[laughing, rattling a box of tic tacs, and talking to the baby]* Hellooooo. Hello in there.

BOB: *[watching her this time. More incredulous than angry or annoyed]* Are you always this cheerful? *[she pauses, uncertain how to react]* I mean you just keep babbling at them like. . .

DAPHNE: They're cute! Don't you think they're cute? *[Bob considers the babies for a moment, shrugs as if to say "sure, if you say so. Daphne begins replacing items in her purse she has been using to amuse the babies. One of the items is a pack of gum, sensing a possible conversation starter, she offers some to him]* Gum?

BOB: No, thanks.

DAPHNE: It's Juicy Fruit. *[Bob shakes his head "no"]* It's alright, really, I've got plenty. I've got kind of a sweet tooth. A whole mouth full of them actually. *[beat. Daphne senses Bob's depression]* My mom always used to say that all you have to do to chase away the blues is look at a sunset. . . or a flower. *[pause]* The beauty of God's creation. *[pause]* Then she'd down another fifth of vodka and pass out on the couch. *[She laughs. Bob walks downstage closer to the babies. Daphne watches him]* It's a valid concept, though, when you think about it. . . the sunset, not the vodka. Although, I suppose. . .

BOB: My wife died today. *[silence]* In childbirth. . . She and the baby both.

DAPHNE: *[softly]* Oh, my. . . Oh my God, I'm. . . Really? I mean. . . I'm sorry. *[pause. Bob turns, sees her expression and bursts out laughing. Daphne is frozen in confusion]* What?

BOB: *[laughs even more hysterically at this reaction]* I'm sorry. *[still laughing]* You just kept yammering.

DAPHNE: You were joking?

BOB: *[nods his head, wiping tears from his eyes]* I'm not even married! *[more laughter]*

DAPHNE: That was. . . HORRIBLE! How COULD you. . .

BOB: *[laughter finally dying down a bit]* Oh, come on. What? *[Daphne turns away]* It was a joke! Come on! If you could have seen the look on your face. *[He bursts into laughter again]* I'm Bob, by the way. *[he reaches out as if to shake hands]*

DAPHNE: I have to go now, Bob. *[she turns to leave, Bob moves with her, blocking her path]*

BOB: What? Come on! It was a joke. I was making conversation.

DAPHNE: CONVERSATION! THAT is NOT "making conversation"! THAT was. . . sick!

BOB: Oh, please. . . come on! You were boring yourself with all that crap about babies and the "beauty of God's creation"!

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DAPHNE: Ok. Fine. But I really need to leave.

BOB: I'm sorry, ok? I'm sorry. I may have been slightly. . . inappropriate, but at least it got us talking. Right? Lunch break can't be over yet, you just got here. We'll talk. *[Daphne clutches her purse to her chest and looks around for another way out]* You can look at the babies. You Look at them. Aren't they cute? *[she looks at the babies, smiles]* My sense of humor takes a little getting used to. Ever since I was a kid. Drove my teachers crazy.

DAPHNE: Well. . . *[polite smile-still wary]* Well, I'm glad I could help you out of your mood. When you came in, you seemed so. . .

BOB: Oh, That. It's nothing, really. I think too much. You can loosen your grip on that purse if you want.

DAPHNE: Oh! I was just. . . I'm sorry. I, um. . .

BOB: Relax. You're perfectly safe. I'm weird, not violent.

DAPHNE: Well. . . *[she tries to relax, without much success]*

BOB: There you go. *[long, uncomfortable pause]*

DAPHNE: So. . . Um. . . Where are you from, Bob?

BOB: Here. Well, not ***here***. I mean not from this hospital. *[nervous laugh. Daphne nods politely]* I just meant here in town. I've been in that diner you work at. You probably don't remember me.

DAPHNE: Well, I. . .

BOB: No, no, I understand. It's a busy place. *[she nods]* You're cheerful there, too. I mean, you have to be, right? You're grouchy, you don't get tips. But it's like you enjoy it or something. *[she smiles]* I mean it can get on your nerves after a while. . . Always cheerful. Always. . . up. Like with the babies before. *[she smiles and looks at the babies. She can't resist a little wave. Bob shakes his head]* Years from now they'll probably all be in therapy. *[she looks at him]* Recurring dreams of a huge lady rattling tic tacs in their face. *[sees her reaction--quickly]* I couldn't do it. Be cheerful all the time. So, where are you from, Daphne?

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DAPHNE: *[surprised, slightly wary]* You know my name? *[Bob points to the name tag on her chest. She's still dressed for work]* Oh! Oh, of course, [my name tag]. *[laughing]* I'm sorry. I'm from Nebraska.

BOB: Nebraska. Wow. I bet they're all like you in Nebraska. Happy, smiling. . . riding horses, milking cows.

DAPHNE: I've never been on a horse in my life. And I've never touched a cow.

BOB: Sure, sure, I believe you. *[small pause -- smiling]*

DAPHNE: You've never been to Nebraska, have you?

BOB: No. But I've read about it. -- Stephen King. "Children of the Corn." And "The Stand". . . that old lady that talked to God. She was from Nebraska.

DAPHNE: *[joking]* If you went by ***those*** books, you'd expect everyone in Nebraska to be like you.

BOB: What do you mean?

DAPHNE: *[slight pause--unsure if she's insulted him or if he's kidding]* I don't know.

BOB: What am I like?

DAPHNE: I don't know. Nothing.

BOB: No, really, I want to know.

DAPHNE: I'm sorry. I didn't mean anything. You're just. . . dark, you know *[very uncomfortable, struggling for words that won't insult him]* somber. . . spooky.

BOB: What do you mean, "spooky"? And somber? What's somber?

DAPHNE: *[throughout the following lines, Daphne becomes increasingly anxious and uncomfortable]* I don't even know you. . .

BOB: What kind of word is "Somber"?

DAPHNE: I'm sorry, I just. . .

BOB: Calling a guy "spooky" and "somber"

DAPHNE: LOOK! YOU ASKED! *[silence]* I mean, I'm sorry if I insulted you. *[pause]* What are you doing here, anyway? Why are you bothering me?

BOB: I didn't know I was bothering you.

DAPHNE: I was having a perfectly good time, and then you come in here. . .

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BOB: *[overlapping slightly--interrupting]* I'm visiting someone. *[small pause]*

DAPHNE: Oh, right, your dead wife and child. I'm so sorry.

BOB: I'm visiting my father.

DAPHNE: *[not believing him]* Your father.

BOB: He's. . . not doing well. I thought, maybe if I came down here, maybe the kids would cheer me up or something.

DAPHNE: Uh huh.

BOB: Look, I'm sorry I said that before, about my wife and kid, it's just. . . well, I knew you were going to ask, sooner or later, why I was here, and I didn't want to talk about it. Ok?

DAPHNE: *[still skeptical, but what if he's telling the truth?]* What's he got? *[pause -- Bob looks at the babies]* I'm sorry. You don't want to talk about it. I'll just. . . *[turns to leave]*

BOB: He shot himself. *[silence]* I found him this morning. *[long pause--Bob stares ahead, expressionless]*

DAPHNE: Oh, Bob. . . Um, you probably want to be alone. *[turns again to go]*

BOB: *[when she's almost out the door]* He left a note. *[she stops]* They always do that in books, you know. In movies. They always have some big message. . . something meaningful. You wanna know what his said? It said, "Bobby, you're the man of the family now. Take care of mother, and always remember *[pause]* people from Nebraska will believe anything you tell them." *[pause]*

DAPHNE: No. *[Bob turns and smiles at her]* Oh, no. *[Bob bursts out in laughter. Daphne is shaken and enraged]* You are SICK!

BOB: Oh, come on! You wanted spooky.

DAPHNE: I did not WANT spooky!

BOB: *[still laughing]* Look, I'm sorry. *[she turns away]* I couldn't resist. It was a joke.

DAPHNE: How could you say something like that? About your father?

BOB: What's the big deal? You never told a joke about your father? Come on. *[she turns to face him]*

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DAPHNE: You want to hear a joke about my father? One night, when I was twelve years old, my father decided to decorate the house for Christmas. About a week before Christmas, dad went out and bought up all of the lights and decorations he could find. There wasn't much left, but he still got a lot. One store owner was so glad to get rid of everything so close to Christmas, that he threw in an old mannequin and Santa costume that had been cluttering up his storeroom. Dad built his whole display around it. *[pause--smiles at the memory]*

We didn't have a big chimney like you see in movies, so he put Santa on the roof of the porch, peering into the window of my parents' bedroom. Around all of the windows, he put red lights. Green lights around the edge of the roof. And combinations criss-crossed up and down in all the bushes and trees. . . It was beautiful.

I remember it was really cold that year, so he did all this with these gloves and a huge coat. I couldn't imagine how, with all those heavy clothes on, he could climb up that ladder and hang all those lights, but he did. And in between each string of lights, he would come down the ladder, pick me up off the ground, spin me around, and sit me up on his shoulders to get a better look. It took almost a week to finish it, but when he finally lit it all up, the whole town came out to see it. Everyone! I was so happy. I was sure that this was going to be the best Christmas in the history of Christmases; living in this. . . cocoon of color and light, with the rest of the world lining up outside to admire it.

On Christmas eve, dad went downtown to this bar that he used to hang out in. He liked to spend Christmas eve with his buddies, because, on Christmas, all the aunts and uncles would be over, and I guess being hungover gave him an excuse not to be a good host. *[small pause]* By the time he got home, it was past midnight. Mom had turned out all the Christmas lights for the night--she couldn't sleep when they were on, because they would shine in through her window--so the only light was from the streetlight at the end of the block, and, I guess, in the darkness, after drinking all night, dad forgot about the Santa mannequin. . . mistook it for a burglar or something because I woke up to hear shouting on the lawn. . . gunshots. . . breaking glass.

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I ran into mom and dad's room, because I didn't know what was happening, but mom and dad weren't in bed. And it was cold, like someone had left the window open, so I looked. . . and there was my mother, just lying there on the floor, in the middle of all this shattered glass and blood. She must have been standing at the window when. . . *[pause--Bob is frozen. Daphne stands staring into space--reliving the story]* and I just stood there. . . I couldn't move. It was like a dream.

But then I heard the front door open, and footsteps running up the stairs. I was terrified. I thought that whoever had been shouting on the lawn must be coming to get me now, and there was no place to hide. The only thing I could think to do was lay down beside my mother and play dead. I thought whoever it was wouldn't hurt me if they thought I was already dead. So, when dad got to the door of the bedroom, he saw me and my mother and all that blood, and. . . he said. . . something. . . it didn't register at first, I was so scared, and concentrating so hard on not moving. . . and then he stumbled backwards out of the room, and I heard him crying and saying, "No, no, no,". . . over and over again. "No, no. . ." *[pause]* and I recognized his voice. It was dad. But before I could say anything there was another gunshot. *[pause]* And then he wasn't crying anymore. *[pause]* I guess he didn't have time to leave a funny note like your dad.

BOB: Oh, God I'm. . . I'm so sorry.

DAPHNE: Well, thank you, Bob, but right now I just really would like to be alone with the babies if you don't mind.

BOB: No. No, of course. I'll just. . . um. . . *[he begins to exit; turns back, can't think of anything to say. Exits.]*

DAPHNE: *[doesn't watch him go, but stares ahead at the babies. She stands expressionless for a moment then smiles at something one of the babies has done. She laughs and waves with her index finger]* Hello. Hello in there. Ahhhhhhhh! *[laughs again -- still speaking to the baby]* Try and ruin my day, will he? Well, that'll teach him teach him, won't it. Yes it will. *[continues to coo, wave to the babies as the lights slowly fade to black]*

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Acting notes from the playwright:

*Though it would seem to be the easy assumption to make (and EVERYONE seems to make it), I think it's much more interesting if Daphne's story *isn't* just a joke. In other words, her story is true, but she still uses it to get back at Bob for what he's done to her. The original inspiration for the piece was my belief that people who are always extremely cheerful and "up" all the time are often the most screwed up people you could ever meet. I think Daphne is the most "disturbed" person in this play, not Bob.*

That being said, I still leave it completely up to the director and/or performer to decide on whether her story is true or not. Either way, the audience and Bob must believe every moment of it. My goal was for the audience to leave the performance still wondering if she (or Bob) was actually lying. Whether or not YOU believe Daphne's story, the audience should still be wondering when they leave your performance.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Brad Bosen
Book: Millennium Monologs: 95 Contemporary Characterizations for Young Actors, ed. Gerald Lee Ratliff - Daphne's Monologue Only, Pgs 147-149
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Full play can be found here: *https://www.geocities.ws/quietharry/pboese02.html*

A note from the playwright: *Monologues may be used at no cost and without prior permission for classes, competitions and auditions, as may small scenes used strictly for classroom or competition purposes. If you do use any of my stuff for auditions, classes and such, though, please e-mail me and tell me how it went for you at* ***mulberries@bjboesen.com***

AWARD HISTORY

2021 National Qualifier – MS
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